NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥K

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦K

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♣6

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 7NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥10

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 2♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠8

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ K 5 4
♥ A J
♦ 7 6 2
♣ A K 8 5 3

♠ 10 2
♥ 10 9 7 4 2
♦ K 10 8 3
♣ Q 6



♠ 3
♥ K Q 8 6 3
♦ Q 9 4
♣ J 10 7 2

♠ A Q J 9 8 7 6
♥ 5
♦ A J 5
♣ 9 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

6♠ by North
Lead: ♥K

Wow. You can tell that this is going to be tough to bid scientifically. You decide to start with a transfer bid, 2♥. Partner replies 2♠.

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You know there are enough points for slam, but not enough for a Grand Slam. Asking for Aces will get you nowhere because if partner shows only one Ace you will still think you should be in slam. So you take a shot and bid 6♠.(If you don't think you would really do this, I won't hold it against you.)

The contract would be 6♠ played by South.

North plays 6♠. East leads the ♥K. Of course you take your ♥A.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2The Losers are counted from dummy's long-trump hand for simplicity.

The ♣ suit must be established to take one of the ♦ losers. But there may be an entry problem since the opening lead has taken out one of your entries already.

Pull trumps in two rounds, (you got a break there), leaving the ♠K in your hand as an entry.

If you now play ♣A, ♣K, and then ruff a ♣ you will succeed when the ♣s split 3-3. But if they are 4-2, then you will fail because you only have the one entry to your hand.

A better plan is to play a small ♣ from each hand. This gives the defense a ♣ trick but you can win their return, play a ♣ to the ♣ A, take the ♣K, then ruff the **FOURTH ♣**. This will establish the **FIFTH ♣** and you still have the ♠K for an entry.

This is a really good idea to keep in mind when you have a doubleton opposite A K x x x.

If you can afford to lose a trick in the suit you can make do with one fewer entry just by ducking the first round. Basically it gives you three plays in the suit before you take your ruff.

But what if the contract had been 7♠?

Obviously you couldn't afford to lose a trick so you would have to bang down the two top ♣s, then ruff one and hope the suit was splitting 3-3.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 8 6 3 ♥ 10 7 5 2 ♦ 5 2 ♣ A 8 7 4	
♠ Q 9 4 ♥ J 8 4 ♦ A J 6 ♣ K 9 5 3	N W E S	♠ K J 10 5 ♥ A K Q ♦ 10 3 ♣ Q J 10 2
	♠ A 7 2 ♥ 9 6 3 ♦ K Q 9 8 7 4 ♣ 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	2♦
2NT	Pass	3♣	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♦K

When using lebensohl, a 2NT bid over an enemy overcall asks partner to bid 3♣. So partner replies 3♣.

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Now you complete the sequence by bidding 3NT. This says that not only do you think 3NT would be a good choice, but also that you have their ♦s stopped.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♦K. What will you play from dummy? (North follows with the ♦2.

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 4

Since South has apparently led from ♦ K Q it seems you will get a second ♦ winner when they pursue the suit. You can also establish 3 more winners in ♣s. You can also establish 3 more winners in ♠s.

But as you can figure, you are going to have to establish **BOTH** black suits to get enough winners, and therein lies the problem. If South has a 5-card ♦ suit they will be able to establish 3 ♦ winners by the time you have knocked out both black Aces. In that case you cannot make the contract. Of course, if the ♦s are split 4-4 you will only lose 2 ♦s and the two black Aces. However South would probably not have overcalled a 4-card suit.

But South might have a 6-card ♦ suit, leaving North with just 2. Assume the two black Aces are split, one with South and one with North. If you win the first trick with dummy's ♦A you will be OK if you first play the black suit where South holds the Ace. He will take it and then establish his ♦s. No problem, because when you knock out North's black Ace he won't have a ♦ left. BUT, if you guess the wrong black suit first you will go down.

You can protect your interests fully just by letting South hold the first ♦, then winning the second as cheaply as you can. At that point North will be out of ♦s so it won't matter which black suit you go for.

The Deal shows South with 6 ♦s to the K Q, the critical situation.

If you take dummy's ♦A at the first trick you will succeed if you next attack ♠s, but you will fail if you next attack ♣s.

But if you hold up on the first trick and win the continuation, you will succeed whichever black suit you attack next.

The holdup would of course fail if South held both black Aces, but in this case no Plan would succeed.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ 10 9 4
♥ Q 8 3
♦ A 10 7 2
♣ K 8 4

♠ A 8 2
♥ 6 5 2
♦ 8 4
♣ A J 9 6 3



♠ J 7 6 3
♥ J 10 9 4
♦ K 5 3
♣ 10 7

♠ K Q 5
♥ A K 7
♦ Q J 9 6
♣ Q 5 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♣6

Partner's 2NT bid invites you to bid game if you have a maximum hand. With 17 points you bid the game.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♣6. You play the ♣4 from dummy, East plays the ♣10 and you take your ♣Q.

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 5

You are pretty sure West has the ♣A so dummy's ♣K can become a winner. If so, you only need 3 more winners.

All 3 can come from the ♦ suit if the finesse works, only 2 if it fails. Assume the worst, so that means you will also need a ♠ winner.

When you give up the lead the opponents are going to continue ♣s if they can. If West has a 5-card ♣ suit you could lose 3 ♣s, the ♠A and the ♦K. Either defender might win the ♠A, but only East can win with the ♦K.

Since West, the Danger hand, can only get in with the ♠A you should establish a ♠ winner first, even though the ♦s are better. Whoever wins the ♠A will probably knock out dummy's ♣K. Hopefully this will not cause you a problem because when your finesse for the ♦K loses to East he won't have another ♣. At least that's the Plan!

If you finesse in ♦s first, East will return his last ♣ and the suit will get established while West still has an entry in the ♠A.

Play ♠s first and even though West can win and establish ♣s East will not have a ♣ to return when he wins his ♦K.

It goes without saying that if your ♠K holds the trick you immediately switch to ♦s.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 8 7 6 4 2 ♥ 10 9 8 3 ♦ 9 8 ♣ 9 6	
♠ K J 10 ♥ A Q 7 ♦ A 7 5 ♣ A Q 7 4	N W E S	♠ A Q 5 ♥ K J 4 ♦ K Q 6 3 ♣ K 3 2
	♠ 9 3 ♥ 6 5 2 ♦ J 10 4 2 ♣ J 10 8 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
2NT	Pass	7NT	
All Pass			

7NT by West
Lead: ♥10

Partner has 20 or 21 points, balanced, and you have 18. You've always wanted to do this haven't you?

The contract would be 7NT played by East.

West plays 7NT. North leads the ♥10 and South follows with the ♥2.

DO NOT HOLD UP.

Winner List: ♠ = 3 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 3 :: Total = 12

There are two chances for your thirteenth winner, your fourth ♣ or dummy's fourth ♦.

Some players will assume that means one of those two suits will have to split 3-3, so they will immediately test one, then the other.

In fact there is another possibility for success - even if neither suit is 3-3 it may be that the same defender holds 4 cards in both suits. In this case that defender can be squeezed. BUT, you don't play the ♣s and ♦s first, you play the other two suits.

Win the first ♥, then play two more ♥s and all three ♠ winners. That will be 6 tricks played, and each defender will be down to 7 cards left in their hand. If one of them happened to start with 4 ♣s and 4 ♦s he will have to discard from one of the holdings and you will be able to win your fourth card in that suit.

Although neither minor suit splits 3-3 it happens that South holds the guard in both suits.

When you play your sixth Major suit winner South is squeezed and must discard from one of his 4-card holdings.

This is an Automatic Squeeze, which just means you don't have to do any preparatory work. All you have to do is play off all your non-threat winners before you play the squeezing suits.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ Q 3 ♥ A 8 6 ♦ Q 7 5 2 ♣ A K 9 4	
♠ A 6 ♥ K 9 2 ♦ K J 3 ♣ J 8 7 3 2	N W E S	♠ J 10 2 ♥ Q J 10 3 ♦ A 10 4 ♣ 10 6 5
	♠ K 9 8 7 5 4 ♥ 7 5 4 ♦ 9 8 6 ♣ Q	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠		
All Pass			

2♠ by North
Lead: ♥Q

Surely this hand will play better in ♠s than in notrump. So you transfer with 2♥ and partner bids 2♠.

Surely this hand will play better in ♠s than in notrump. So you transfer with 2♥ and partner bids 2♠.

You pass. In the old days, before transfers, you would have bid 2♠ with this hand as a sign-off. The only difference is that now partner gets to play it.

The contract would be 2♠ played by South.

North plays 2♠. East leads the ♥Q and West plays the ♥9.

Loser List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 7

Suppose you win the ♥A, play over to the ♣Q, then try to get back to your hand with a trump to discard 2 losers on ♣ A K. If it worked that way it would be fine, but it is very likely that a defender would win their trump Ace, then take their 2 ♥s and 3 ♦s. You could be down one before you even got started.

A better approach is to trade one of your ♣ winners for a quick discard. Take the ♥A, then play ♣ A K, discarding a ♥ from dummy. That will eliminate one ♥ loser.

You probably cannot avoid your 3 ♦ losers, but you may be able to get out with losing a single trump. **IF** ♠s split 3-2, and **IF** you can win tricks with both the ♠K and ♠Q then you will make it. The only way it can happen is if West holds a doubleton ♠ A x. You must play the first ♠ from dummy, so ruff a ♣ to get there, then lead a small ♠, putting on your ♠Q when West follows low. This wins the trick, (hip-hip), so you now play your ♠3, ducking in dummy. When West has to take his ♠A, (hooray), you are home-free.

With West holding the ♠A, this Plan clearly works.

But, if you need West to hold the ♠ A x anyway, perhaps that first plan would have worked better. You know, take dummy's ♣Q, then play a low ♠ to get to your hand.

It depends on West. If he ducked the low ♠ then you could get **TWO** discards and make an overtrick.

The method given here gives up the possibility of an overtrick for an improved chance of making the contract. You choose.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ K J 6 2 ♥ 3 ♦ 9 8 4 2 ♣ Q 10 6 3	
♠ A 7 5 3 ♥ K J 10 9 4 ♦ Q 6 5 ♣ 7	N W E S	♠ Q 10 9 4 ♥ A Q 8 6 ♦ A K ♣ A J 4
	♠ 8 ♥ 7 5 2 ♦ J 10 7 3 ♣ K 9 8 5 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2NT	Pass
3♣	Pass	3♥	Pass
6♥			
All Pass			

6♥ by East
Lead: ♠8

First find out about Major suit fits by bidding Stayman. So bid 3♣ and partner says 3♥. What now?

First find out about Major suit fits by bidding Stayman. So bid 3♣ and partner says 3♥. What now?

Feel free to use Blackwood. But if partner shows 3 Aces you only have enough points to bid 6, and if he shows 2 Aces you would still bid 6. So Blackwood will keep you out of slam if he has only 1 Ace. Or, you could just take a chance and bid 6♥.

The contract would be 6♥ played by West.

To rotate the hands and make East the declarer

East plays 6♥. South leads the ♠8. To play the ♠A or not to play the ♠A, that is the question.

Loser List: ♠ = 2? : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

At first thought it seems the ♠ lead has saved you a guess in the suit. By playing low in dummy you will force North to put on the King, (if he has it), winning the trick but leaving you with a pretty good position in ♠s.

That's why it's good to have second thoughts at the Bridge table. Think about the meaning of the ♠8 lead. If it is fourth down, then the Rule of 11 tells you that there will be 3 cards higher than the 8 spread among West, North, and East. **BUT YOU CAN SEE 4 HIGHER CARDS**. So your conclusion is that South has **NOT** made a fourth-down lead, but rather has led top-of-nothing, top-of-a-doubleton, or perhaps a singleton.

You don't know which of the above, but you do know that North holds both the ♠ K J. The danger is if the ♠8 is a singleton and you play low from dummy they could get a ♠ trick and a ♠ ruff. So don't play low from dummy. Win the ♠A at trick 1, pull trumps and then play ♠s from dummy toward your ♠ Q 10 9, giving North the ♠K but finessing him out of his known ♠J.

If North led the ♠8 from ♠ 8 6 2 then it wouldn't matter whether you played the ♠A or not, you would always make the contract.

If North led the ♠8 from ♠ 8 6 or ♠ 8 2 then it also wouldn't matter whether you played the ♠A or not, you would always make the contract.

If North led the singleton ♠8 then you had better play the ♠A or you will be down before you start.

It is unlikely that North would lead the ♠8 from any holding containing one or both of the honors.